Blaize Giangiulio

Contact Information

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Education

Drexel University, Philadelphia, PA **2022–2027 (expected)**
Ph.D., Economics; Ph.D. Candidate since September 2024
Expected completion: June 2027
Dissertation Co-Chairs: Constantinos Syropoulos and Yoto V. Yotov

McGill University, Montreal, QC, Canada
M.A., Economics **2021**
B.A., Economics, with Distinction **2020**

Fields

International Trade, Applied Industrial Organization, Applied Econometrics

Job Market Paper

"Trade Chokepoints" **2026**
Draft available at blaizegiangiulio.com

Trade chokepoints have become targets of armed disruption, although existing work treats such episodes as exogenous hazards. This paper models chokepoint disruption as a strategic choice. In a multi-country model, a disruptor country may pay to raise trade costs between other countries, diverting demand toward itself. Disruption therefore improves the disruptor's terms of trade even absent any geopolitical motive, and the gain grows with the corridor's importance to world trade. Retaliation that raises the disruptor's own trade costs extinguishes this economic motive while leaving a geopolitical motive untouched. I take the model to the 2023–24 Red Sea crisis using a new, network-based measure of logistical distance that captures each country pair's exposure to disruption of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait. Trade fell on exposed pairs, most sharply among Western-aligned pairs, and welfare losses rise with exposure while Iran's own gain is small. Treating the observed campaign as Iran's optimal choice reveals extraordinary leverage: slight intensification would gain Iran $48 to $78 million per year while costing the average Western economy $1.6 to $8.1 billion. Pure self-interest can rationalize the campaign only if it cost Iran under $78 million per year, below even the lowest estimate of Iran's annual support to the Houthis. Rationalizing it therefore requires a strictly positive weight on harming adversaries: in the benchmark calibration, Iran is willing to give up one dollar of its own welfare to destroy roughly $12 of Western welfare.

Working Papers

"Perceived Protection: Tariff Spillovers to Product Substitutes in the Used Car Market" **2026**
with Sebastien Bradley, Mian Dai, and Yoto V. Yotov *CGPA Working Paper 2026-16*

Studies the spillover effects of the 2025 "Liberation Day" automotive tariffs on the untaxed U.S. used-car market. Using over eight million weekly web-scraped listings and a VIN-based crosswalk identifying each vehicle's country of assembly, documents an immediate and persistent 0.2–0.6% increase in the prices of foreign-brand used vehicles relative to domestic-brand vehicles, concentrated among the newest model years—the closest substitutes for new cars—and consistent with demand-side substitution. Foreign-brand vehicles assembled in the U.S. appreciate as much as those assembled abroad, suggesting that the perceived foreignness of a vehicle is largely independent of its true production location. Neglecting tariff pass-through to untaxed substitutes understates overall consumer incidence.

"Logistic Distance" **2026**
with Peter Herman, Serge Shikher, and Yoto V. Yotov
This paper employs geospatial network data to construct a novel transportation-network-informed distance variable that integrates realistic city-to-city freight routing into the Mayer and Zignago (2011) population-weighted distance formula, rendering bilateral distances that are meaningfully responsive to infrastructure shocks. Using the 2023 Red Sea crisis as a natural experiment, we estimate a saturated gravity model in an event-study framework with importer–exporter–time and country-pair fixed effects on monthly bilateral trade data. Treated country pairs are those whose network-informed distance rises meaningfully following the closure of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, identified against a control group of unaffected pairs.

"Dynamic Distance, Trade, and Welfare" **2026**
with James E. Anderson, Peter Herman, Serge Shikher, and Yoto V. Yotov
We introduce a time-varying measure of distance between and within countries and demonstrate its usefulness in international economics applications. Built from annual population data for 6,162 cities in 235 countries from 1950 to 2024, the measure improves gravity estimation by enabling theoretically consistent distance estimates in the presence of bilateral fixed effects, mitigating endogeneity concerns related to unobservable factors. We confirm the previous finding that the effects of distance have fallen over time and show that this decline has been driven primarily by affluent countries. Within a general equilibrium setting, we demonstrate that a counterfactual reversion to mid-century distances produces large welfare changes ranging from -1.4% to $+2.4\%$, suggesting that geographic population shifts since the mid-twentieth century have benefited some countries and hurt others. U.S. migration to the South and West has had particularly large impacts on trade and welfare in Canada and Mexico.

Work in Progress

"Shrouded by Statute: Mandated Used-Car Warranties and the Market" **2026**
Asks whether state used-car lemon laws, which often require dealers to attach a short express warranty to vehicles sold below sharp odometer cutoffs (e.g., 125,000 miles in Massachusetts), generate price premiums. Using 9.9 million web-scraped listings and a regression-discontinuity design with rich fixed effects, finds no warranty premium, alongside pronounced bunching of odometer readings just above the Massachusetts cutoff and reallocation of near-cutoff inventory across state lines. Rationalizes both facts with a shrouded-attribute model in the spirit of Gabaix and Laibson (2006): when buyers unaware of the mandate are the marginal buyers of covered vehicles, the equilibrium premium is zero regardless of the dealer's cost; dealers have no private incentive to debias buyers because disclosure raises claims costs, cannibalizes service-contract sales, and is a public good among rivals; and the resulting unpriced cost acts as a tax on covered sales that is shifted onto the quantity margin. Calibrated simulations reproduce the observed magnitudes of both the null price effect and the Massachusetts bunching.

"Drivers of Economic Gains from European Integration:
A Two-Stage Analysis of Directional Effects Across 50,000 Industry–Country Pairs" **2026**
with Lionel Fontagné, Nicoletta Scutifero, and Yoto V. Yotov

"EQUIP: Enterprise for Quantitative International Policy" **2025–present**
with Ohyun Kwon, Mario Larch, Constantinos Syropoulos, and Yoto V. Yotov
A large-scale computable general-equilibrium policy-evaluation platform under development at Drexel's Center for Global Policy Analysis. EQUIP embeds highly granular input–output linkages across industries and countries within a structural gravity framework and is built on state-of-the-art trade and production data, enabling ex ante quantification of how trade-policy shocks propagate through global value chains to sector-level output, trade flows, and welfare.

Software

"Arteries: Exact Multimodal Transport Distances Between World Cities" **2026**
Python package, v0.1.0 github.com/bgian123/arteries
A Python package that computes the lowest-cost road-and-sea route between all 2,075 cities with more than 100,000 people, built from OpenStreetMap road networks for 236 countries, global shipping lanes, and 1,804 ports. User-chosen prices for road kilometers, sea kilometers, and port calls, along with closures of chokepoints or entire sea regions, yield exact network distances for all 4.3 million city pairs in seconds.

Presentations

"Trade Chokepoints," Philadelphia Trade Group	October 2026
"Perceived Protection," Philadelphia Trade Group	May 2026
"Logistic Distance," Pennsylvania Economic Association Annual Conference	Spring 2025
"Logistic Distance," Philadelphia Trade Group	March 2025
Drexel Sanctions Workshop (participant)	2024

Drexel University Brown Bag Seminar

"Perceived Protection"	2025
"Logistic Distance"	2024
"Dynamic Distance"	2023

Fellowships and Awards

Fellow, Center for Global Policy Analysis, Drexel University	2025–present
Dragon Fellowship, Drexel University	2022–present
Master's Teaching Assistantship, McGill University	2020–2021

Teaching Experience

Teaching Awards

Dr. Tom Hindelang Outstanding Ph.D. Student Instructor Award, Drexel University	2025
Teaching Assistant Excellence Award, Drexel University	2024

Instructor of Record, Drexel University

ECON 201, Principles of Microeconomics	Fall 2024, Fall 2025, Fall 2026
ECON 301, Intermediate Microeconomics	Spring 2026
Ph.D. Math Camp	Summer 2025, Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant, Drexel University

ECON 961, Empirical International Trade (Ph.D.)	Winter 2025
ECON 201, Principles of Microeconomics	Fall 2022–present
ECON 202, Principles of Macroeconomics	Summer 2025, Summer 2026
ECON 301, Intermediate Microeconomics	Fall 2023, Spring 2025, Fall 2025
ECON 250, Game Theory and Applications	Summer 2025
INTB 336, International Money and Finance	Summer 2025
BUSN 924, Analyzing Quantitative Data	Spring 2023, Spring 2024
ECON 902, Mathematical Economics	Fall 2023
ECON 610, Microeconomics	Summer 2023
ECON 350, Applied Econometrics	Fall 2022

ECON 326, Economic Ideas — Fall 2022

Teaching Assistant, McGill University
ECON 209, Introductory Macroeconomics — 2020–2021

Research Experience

Center for Global Policy Analysis, Drexel University
Fellow — **2025–present**
Contributed to the development of the large-scale EQUIP trade simulation model; developed a geospatially founded logistic distance measure; built distributed estimation pipelines on HPC clusters (Slurm), scaling to 5,000+ PPML regressions with high-dimensional fixed effects.

U.S. International Trade Commission, Washington, DC
Student Trainee (Economist) — **2024–2025**
Studied the effect of population movements on international trade flows in a structural gravity framework; used geospatial data and graph-theoretic methods in Python to predict shipping routes and construct a new logistic distance variable; supported Section 337 (unfair import practices) and antidumping/countervailing duty (AD/CVD) investigations; provided technical assistance to USTR.

Drexel University
Research Assistant to Yoto V. Yotov — **2022–present**
Assembled, cleaned, and analyzed data from a wide range of trade sources in R and Stata; prepared summaries of trade-policy research.

Professional Service

Referee: *Defence and Peace Economics*, *Economics Letters*, *Review of International Economics*, *The World Economy*

Skills

Programming: Stata, Python, R, MATLAB, SQL, Bash, Slurm (HPC), LaTeX
Languages: English (native), French (fluent)

References

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